> The old and infirm who come near to death, and those entangled in a severe sickness, who fear to linger to the end of their days, and through disgust wish to escape the troubles of life, or those who desire release from the trifling affairs of the world and its concerns, these, after receiving a farewell meal at the hands of their relatives or friends, they place, amid the sounds of music, on a boat which they propel into the midst of the Ganges, where such persons drown themselves.

Brahmins versus Bodhisattvas

Brahminism and Buddhism, the two dominant games in town, had common roots and many overlapping beliefs and customs. Religious life, especially among the laity, was fairly syncretic across most orthodox (Brahminical) and heterodox (Sramanic) belief systems. But the two also had real differences, which at times bubbled up in strong mutual distrust and hostility, especially at elite and institutional levels. Faxian relates a few examples. His account, though partial to the Buddhist point of view, reveals a combative dynamic between the two groups. When Shravasti was rising as a Buddhist town and accruing monuments that honoured the Buddha, he writes, ‘The Brahmins with their contrary doctrine, became full of hatred and envy in their hearts, and wished to destroy them, but there came from the heavens such a storm of crashing thunder and flashing lightning that they were not able in the end to affect their purpose.’

Xuanzang also describes a failed plot in which 500 Brahmins, jealous and resentful of Harsha’s ‘excessive’ patronizing of Buddhism, hired a killer to assassinate Harsha. Other kings, such as of Karnagarh in Bihar and Brahmanapura in Malwa, reportedly hosted well-attended and often bitter debates—philosophical boxing contests, if you will— between Brahmins and Bodhisattvas, with the latter invariably reported as victors in Chinese accounts, and being rewarded with fame, fortune and increased royal patronage for their monasteries. Notably, many of the star Buddhist philosopher monks were Brahmin by birth, and had joined what they likely considered a more satisfying scholastic fold of inquiry, debate and mode of being.[25] This perhaps added another layer of complexity to their rivalry with former co-religionists.

Xuanzang himself joined animated debates with Brahmins in Harsha’s court, and even at Nalanda. A Brahmin challenger once showed up at Nalanda and asked for a debate. He ‘wrote out forty theses and hung them